Why the Next Seat at the Table Might Be a Council, Not a Director

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Architecture of the Boardroom Is Being Rebuilt While It Is Still Occupied

The session set out to examine three shifts at once: how the classic seats in the boardroom – chair, director and corporate secretary – have changed; whether frontier expertise in AI, science and geopolitics should enter the board through a standing council rather than another director; and what single test every board decision should pass. What emerged was less a debate about titles than about foundations. The conversation kept returning to one point: no structural fix – a new seat, a council, a committee, an AI tool – works until owners, directors and executives share an explicit philosophy of governance, anchored in one question: what is good for the company?

Participants brought experience from listed companies, family-owned groups, foundation-anchored companies, private equity portfolios, state-owned enterprises and boards in the Gulf. The discussion was candid, at times provocative, and occasionally contradictory – which is precisely what Board Agora sessions are designed for.

Key insights

- Great execution with bad governance is the worst combination. Executing well in the wrong direction destroys more value than poor execution. Governance decides the direction; execution only accelerates it.
- Philosophy before structure. Every director carries a private philosophy of governance. Where these are never reconciled, a board of capable people pulls in four directions at once.
- The board is responsible for the company – not for the shareholders, the owners, the CEO or the chair. Shareholders disagree among themselves and move on; the company is the only constant to which the board can be loyal.
- Three boards, one governance. In owner-led companies, an owners' board sets mission, values and the rules of the game; the board of directors governs the company; executives run the business. Each owns a different strategy.

- Structure, relations, people. Good structure is necessary but never sufficient. Most governance codes speak of structure and process and say almost nothing about people and how they interact.
- The roles have shifted – but the bigger change may be the information. The chair now listens and speaks last; the corporate secretary has become a trusted advisor; directors are more engaged. Yet the deepest asymmetry remains what the board knows, and when.
- AI moves the board meeting from information to judgement. If information becomes abundant, the scarce resource is judgement – and the diversity of minds that sharpens it.
- Advisors and councils are useful – at the right level. Expertise should sit with the body that needs it. A board that compensates for its composition by surrounding itself with advisors, risks becoming a parliament.
- Be creative about governance; avoid routine. Learning expeditions, joint strategy workshops with management and anonymous end-of-meeting feedback build the trust that lets a board speak up when it matters.

I. THE OPENING PROVOCATION

Every Seat Has Changed

The session opened with a deliberately concrete example. Two weeks before the session, one of Europe's most strategic industrial groups changed its chair. The outgoing chair stepped down after many years to concentrate on a single chairmanship elsewhere, relinquishing other responsibilities. Into the seat came the sitting CEO of a company at the very frontier of semiconductor technology.

Two lessons were drawn. First, chairing a major company is no longer something one does alongside other roles: it requires full attention. Second, boards are increasingly filling their most important seats with people who live at the frontier right now, because they need that perspective in the room – not described to them second-hand.

A gap boards recognise but cannot close fast enough

Research from established advisory houses, based on a survey of around a thousand directors in Europe, suggests that roughly 71% believe their board lacks the capabilities it will need. Put the other way, only 29% believe the expertise in their boardroom today is sufficient for what lies ahead – and that is before adding science and geopolitics to technology and AI. No director can hold all of this, and no election cycle can close the gap quickly enough: a board can only renew so many seats per year. Hence the emergence, in some boards, of standing external councils – a form of

consigliere – designed to bring timely knowledge into board discussions without occupying a seat.

Three seats, three new roles

Seat	Yesterday	Today
The Chair	Decider: the ruling figure at the head of the table, followed by the board	Listener: ensures every voice is heard, speaks last, brings the fragments together and closes the debate when it matters
The Director	Overseer: chosen for a single area of expertise	Judge: valued for maturity of judgement across topics and for working as part of a team rather than as an impressive individual
The Corporate Secretary	Organiser: makes sure meetings happen	Governance Officer: often without a new title, the trusted go-to person across management, board and stakeholders

Most boards, the host suggested, have not yet rewritten the job descriptions to reflect these shifts.

The red line as a litmus test

The third angle was framed as a red line – or better, a litmus test that every board decision should pass: is this good for the company? Not for the CEO, not for the chair, not for the shareholders, and not even for today's owners, but for the long-term future of the company itself. This, it was argued, is not merely an ethical line. It is a strategy. The board's job has shifted from supervising risks to choosing them – and not choosing can be the biggest risk of all.

"The red line is not an ethical nice-to-have. It is a strategy. Not taking a decision is an even bigger risk than walking through blindly."

II. THE ACADEMIC LENS

Great Execution, Bad Governance: The Most Expensive Combination

Ludo opened with personal history. Growing up in a region full of family-owned small and medium-sized enterprises, he saw businesses on both sides of his family fail – one sold too late in the third generation, another liquidated in the second. With hindsight, he concluded that the root cause was not weak execution but weak governance. His formulation became a thread through the session:

"The worst thing is great execution and bad governance. That is real value destruction. Bad governance with no execution is not so bad. The worst is to keep executing in the wrong direction."

- Ludo

He came to teach governance after the financial crisis, which he described as fundamentally a governance crisis. One early encounter stayed with him: a chief executive, when offered help with his board, replied that the board did not listen to him – so why would it listen to a professor? The lesson he took from years of teaching boards is that directors need to learn faster and more than anyone else, because they must supervise executives. Business schools do not create great board members, he argued; at best they help board members develop.

Unlike managers, directors cannot rely on learning from mistakes. Every board meeting is like the final of a competition, and boards keep repeating the same errors – hiring the wrong CEO again and again.

Governance is under-studied – and every board is unique

Ludo was blunt about the state of the field: there are some four hundred years of study of management, but very little serious academic work on governance beyond financial studies of outcomes such as whether CEO duality matters. There are principles, but every board is unique, and the honest answer to most governance questions is "it depends on the context".

He offered a working definition. Performance results from four factors: the environment (above all the choice of sector – where you choose to fight); the organisation (whether it can execute); the strategy (what the major battles are and what victory looks like); and leadership (whether you have the right generals). Governance is the work of keeping these four aligned. And as the world automates, he suggested, more and more people will spend their time doing governance, because execution will increasingly be done by machines.

Why boards fall behind

Ludo sees the arrival of AI as a discontinuity that will force every board to review itself – not as a technology question but as a question about what the world will look like. Boards have always tended to lag. The most acute form of lag, in his view, is when a CEO becomes chair: this anchors the company in the past, regardless of the individual's qualities. Drawing on his own time in an executive role, he observed how naturally a CEO takes board challenge personally – which is exactly why a counterweight is needed. Visionary CEOs are, almost by definition, a little delusional; occasionally the delusion becomes reality. One company he cited rose from a distant ranking to global leadership in its industry, then found its market shifting beneath it. It applied a rule worth remembering: if we change strategy, we change the CEO. CEOs are specialists in a particular way of creating value; a leader who built through acquisition is unlikely to be the right one for organic growth.

III. PHILOSOPHY BEFORE STRUCTURE

A Joint Philosophy of Governance

Ludo's first substantive proposition was that a board needs a joint governance philosophy – philosophy in the original Greek sense of philos and sophia: one must care about wisdom. Where that shared philosophy is missing, capable people pull in different directions.

Four philosophies around one table

He illustrated the point with his experience on the supervisory board of a large state-owned energy company operating in a country at war. Around a table of seven, he counted at least four distinct governance philosophies. One director, shaped by an earlier privatisation, saw the mission as preparing for privatisation – and therefore avoided engaging with the state as owner. Another, shaped by a different market, believed governance was essentially about compensation and incentives. A third believed in quiet, one-to-one diplomacy with the government. The state representatives felt unable to speak against their principal. The owner, meanwhile, held the view that the board itself was an obstacle and preferred to talk directly to the CEO.

The board was eventually dismissed. With no board in place, responsibility for the company reverted to the owner – and some nineteen months later, the owner concluded that a government at war could not run its largest energy company and asked the board to return. The episode, Ludo argued, illustrates a fundamental truth: power in governance cannot simply be taken; it also has to be given. And the critical

lever is the appointment of the CEO. Once owners bypass the board on that decision, the board loses its authority, however well it is constituted.

"If the owners, the directors and the executives do not share the same philosophy – that the board is responsible for the company – governance does not work."

— Ludo

Which shareholder?

Ludo challenged the reflex, common even among experienced directors, that the board works for "the shareholders". Which shareholders? Shareholders disagree: some want the long term, others the short term. In the energy example, one ministry wanted more energy, another wanted more dividends, and the head of state wanted cheap gas for citizens. The value transferred to customers through subsidised prices ended up many times the company's profits. The mission, he concluded, is set by the owners – and when there are a million dispersed shareholders, that discussion falls on the board. But since the board is appointed through processes the CEO often shapes, the CEO tends to take over.

This led to a strong view on CEO duality. Where chair and CEO are combined, he argued, governance effectively ceases to exist. In his view, the firm separation of the two roles in Switzerland makes it structurally a stronger governance environment than jurisdictions where combination remains common.

Plato's governors

Ludo turned to Plato's Republic for a frame. Only philosophers should govern the city – meaning people committed to discovering what the city, or the company, could truly be, and then making that potential real. Plato identified two threats: those driven by material interests, who pursue their own truth rather than the truth; and the sophists – people who sound brilliant and persuasive but bring the wrong ideas for this organisation in this environment. Everyone admires how clever they are, and the result is value destruction.

Hence his discomfort with the word "independence". Directors must be detached from private interests, but they are anything but independent of the mission of the company. Equally, share price is not a measure of performance: markets can rise for reasons that have nothing to do with how well a company is governed.

"The board's question is: what could the company truly be? That is the philosophical search."

— Ludo

IV. THE PRACTITIONER'S LENS

Governance Under Pressure: The View from the Secretary's Chair

David began with how he came to his role some twenty years ago. He joined in the aftermath of a true governance crisis: a proposal to combine the roles of CEO and chair had been contested by a shareholder motion, and the board prevailed with barely more than half of the votes – despite the CEO signalling that he would step down if the motion passed. The near-miss became the trigger to rebuild the company's governance. The lesson, for David, is simple: governance is critical, and it matters most in a crisis.

He offered a gentle counterpoint to Ludo on where power sits. In the Swiss system, he noted, power ultimately rests with the board; the CEO is the board's hired delegate. That is precisely why the way governance is set up matters so much.

Good governance as a defence against activism

Drawing on experience of an activist campaign, David described governance not as bureaucracy but as a strategic asset. Long-standing mechanisms – notably regular chair's roundtables with investors in different regions – gave the board a ready platform to speak directly to the other 99% of shareholders and make the case for its strategy. When the activist accused the board of using these meetings as a campaign tool, the company could show that they were established practice, unrelated to the contest. Good governance built in calm times becomes a bulwark in turbulent ones.

What does not work: information gaps and time delays

Asked where governance falls short, David pointed to two persistent issues. The first is the information gap between board and management, where AI may help. The second is the time delay in replacing a CEO. When a once-successful CEO is no longer the right person, boards for good reasons typically take six months to a year to act. No board fires a CEO at the first signs of trouble – and arguably it should not rush the most important decision it takes. But from the outside, the delay often looks inexplicable.

From the secretary's seat, the early signals are visible: directors begin talking in small groups over dinner rather than as one board; questions in meetings become sharper and answers are no longer accepted. Recognising these signals is part of the secretary's craft.

The client is the company

The corporate secretary in reality reports to both the chair and the CEO, which places the role between strong personalities precisely when stakes are highest – for instance during a CEO change. David's compass is the same red line the host had proposed: the client is the company. One works for the company, and not only for one of the individuals involved.

"At the end, the client is the company. You work for the company – not only for one of the individuals involved."

— David

How the three seats have changed

Asked to reflect on twenty years of change, David described the corporate secretary role in three 'buckets': the organisational and administrative core; adjacent substantive functions such as corporate legal or compliance, through which the secretary gains influence over the Board's agenda; and, ideally, the role of trusted advisor to the board and the chair – sought out not only for legal advice but on a much wider range of questions.

The chair, he agreed, is no longer the dominant figure but a first among equals. Techniques matter: the chair gives his or her view last and lets other directors speak first. Some chairs now speak bilaterally with every director before each meeting. The chair's central task is to make the board work as a team that asks the right questions from every angle. It is not the board's role to give all the answers.

Directors, finally, have become far more engaged, spend more time and challenge more than they used to. David's guidance to new board members remains: nose in, hands out, eyes to the future.

V. OWNERS, DIRECTORS, EXECUTIVES

Three Boards, One Governance

A participant with experience of a privately owned company sitting beneath a foundation raised a practical tension. The foundation structure brought a valuable long-term focus, but also a tendency to be too conservative and too slow, anchored in the legacy the company wished to preserve. What changes are needed?

Ludo answered conceptually. Governance works best, in his view, when there is an explicit owners' board – whether called an owners' group, an owners' council or, in this case, a foundation board. Its job is to set three things: the mission, the values, and the rules of the game – including the specifications for who can lead the company. The board of directors is there to implement that mission and, where needed, to

influence the owners to reconsider it. The most consequential decisions – which sector to be in, increasingly which countries, and who is CEO – sit at this interface.

In widely held listed companies, by contrast, everyone is an owner and nobody is. The result is entropy, in which direction is set by default by the CEO – above all where chair and CEO roles can be combined.

Complementarity, not silos

Ludo described governance in owner-led companies as residing in three bodies at once – ownership, the board of directors and the executives – distinct but bound together, like offence, midfield and defence in a football team. He drew a sharp distinction between three different strategies that boards often confuse when they debate "who owns strategy":

Strategy	Owned by	Core question
Ownership strategy	The owners	Do we keep investing or do we sell? Do we enter another country or sector? Are we a value-adding owner?
Corporate (board) strategy	The board of directors	What are the major corporate battles – capital commitment, CEO succession and the defining choices of the company?
Business (executive) strategy	The executives	How do we win in our markets?

When a board asks who owns strategy, Ludo's answer is another question: which strategy?

The informal triangle

One practice he called simple and remarkably effective: regular informal meetings between the head of the owners' board, the chair of the board of directors and the CEO. These conversations surface concerns early, close the time gap described by David, and build trust and mutual understanding. They also uphold one cardinal rule: never surprise the CEO, because surprise destroys trust.

It depends on people – and on clarity of roles

A participant serving on the board of a company with an anchor investor and a foundation behind it described an outstanding alignment across all three levels. That

alignment, the participant felt, owed much to the individuals involved – above all a family representative who listens attentively and knows how to fine-tune views across the levels – together with a strong chair and shared values. Where such people are absent, the same structure becomes much harder to make work.

Others agreed that such structures require exceptional clarity on roles. When owners begin to micromanage strategy or insist on a veto over CEO selection, conflict follows. Where roles are unclear, those with private agendas move into the vacuum. A participant had seen an owners' structure work remarkably well in a large privately held food-system group, which began preparing years in advance for the impact of weight-loss drugs on its investments. The same participant had seen similar setups fail elsewhere. What made the difference, in the end, was clarity on the governance principles: why are we here?

VI. THE COUNCIL QUESTION IN PRACTICE

Family Boards, Advisors and Councils

A participant serving on family and listed boards in the Gulf brought the council question into sharp focus. Family businesses make up around 70% of the regional economy, and their boards are frequently populated by family members who are difficult to replace. The prevailing response is to add advisors – on cybersecurity, AI or international policy – rather than change board composition. How should advisory boards work alongside established boards, and what is the trend?

Separate the owners from the board

Ludo acknowledged that advisors are proliferating but described a different approach. When he is brought into a family firm, it is often not doing well; there are too many family members on the board, and the founder does not want to leave. His solution is to create an owners' board, which the founder can chair – honouring a role and a value system in which age and experience command great respect – and which then appoints a professional board of directors.

Some overlap between the two is healthy, to avoid silos. But the family should appoint directors collectively, rather than allocating seats according to shareholdings. He described the word "representative" as toxic: a director is collectively responsible for the corporation, not for a branch of shareholders. He pointed to one legal tradition in which a formally designated shareholder representative cannot vote, precisely because of the potential conflict with what is good for the company. A family observer, by contrast, can be valuable: transparency is the best way to build trust.

He drew a further distinction: the family council (how do we govern the family?) must not be confused with the owners' board (how do we use the family's capital and are

we a value-adding owner?). Family, ownership and business management are three separate spheres.

Advisors at every level – but not a parliament

Ludo's answer to the council question was that each body should have the advisors it needs. Owners may have their own advisors; the board of directors benefits from business, corporate and financial expertise; executives have always had advisors in the form of consultants. AI will increasingly help clarify what advice is truly needed and which questions to ask.

What he does not recommend is keeping a family-dominated board and surrounding it with advisors. These risk creating a parliament and multiplying conflicts of interest – for instance where two major shareholder groups each bring their own advisors, as if two funds were each working with their own consulting firm.

"What I don't do is keep the family as the board of directors with lots of advisors. That creates a parliament – and conflicts of interest."

— Ludo

Principles can be broken – but not for long

Ludo was careful to stress that there is no universal best practice. Principles can be violated, but not for too long. Combining chair and CEO during a crisis may be justified; but if so, the lead independent director should run board meetings, because crises are emotional, the combined chair-CEO will be defensive, and only an independent figure can facilitate objectively and raise the difficult questions.

Family firms and listed companies are different worlds

A participant with long experience on family-company boards stressed the need to distinguish clearly between family-owned and listed companies. Families often want the CEO and chair roles combined, and it can take years to convince them otherwise. The participant's rule: if the CEO is a family member, the chair of the owners' board should not be – and vice versa. By the fifth or sixth generation, it is often a matter of luck whether the family still produces someone capable of running an organisation of thousands of people.

The participant's conclusion was that the most important role of any board, one-tier or two-tier, is to select the right people – who will not always be family members – and that a joint governance philosophy is the foundation for doing so. A director with

a private-equity background can bring welcome rationality to family boards, where emotion tends to run high.

THE COUNCIL QUESTION – WHAT THE ROOM SUGGESTED

- External expertise is useful, but it belongs with the body that needs it: owners, board or executives.
- A council cannot compensate for a board whose composition is wrong. Advisors added to an unreformed board risk creating a parliament.
- Seats are best reserved for judgement; expertise can sit alongside them.
- Without a shared philosophy of governance, a council adds information, not wisdom.

VII. STRUCTURE, RELATIONS, PEOPLE

The Diversity That Actually Matters

A participant pushed back on Ludo's earlier claim that private equity offers the best form of governance. Having served on two private-equity boards, the participant had witnessed every kind of dysfunction – from owners repeatedly interfering with a high-performing management team to a split ownership in which the parties could not agree on basic governance practices. Ludo accepted the challenge: his experience of a well-governed private-equity board was real, but it rested on a clearly written governance philosophy. There is no guarantee.

He then set out what he considers the three pillars of governance performance:

- Structure – the constitutional definition of roles, such as the role of the chair.
- Relations – the interactions, communication and process between people.
- People – whether a given individual fits a given role.

All three are needed. People in the wrong structures will do the wrong things; people with the wrong communication will do the wrong things. In Ludo's view, the major shortcoming of the leading international governance guidelines is that they speak at length about structure and relationships but almost nothing about people. And some people are simply wrong for a role – not because they are bad, but because the fit is poor.

A bad chair is a governance problem – and therefore everyone's problem

Directors often say: "The chair is bad; it's not my problem." Ludo rejected this. Directors are there for the corporation. If the chair is not working, that is a governance problem the board must fix – which requires building alliances rather than confronting the chair alone and helping the chair do the job. Selection matters too: modern psychometric assessment makes it possible to test listening, and he urged boards not to appoint a chair, or a director, who cannot listen.

Diversity in a larger sense

Ludo was candid that the challenge of diversity is not finding it but managing it – differences that are attractive in principle can be hard to live with in practice. The diversity he values at board level is threefold:

- Three cultures – because one cannot fully see a culture from inside it, and because two cultures tend to polarize at opposing extremes; a third one allows and creates relativity. In a country whose governance culture is weak, appoint a foreigner – and even better three foreigners - from a stronger one – or, even better, a local who understands both the local culture and good governance.
- Three industries – to bring different patterns of experience and avoid sector blind spots.
- Three executive functions – so that the board can hold a generalist conversation informed by different disciplines.

Board work, he argued, should be a generalist conversation, while executive management needs specialists. Assembling diverse people is not the hardest part; making them work together is. Selection of people who know how to work and benefit from diversity and knowing how to interact effectively are the keys. If the structure is right, people will more easily reveal themselves.

He added that a good director must be a "protestant," namely someone willing to keep challenging, even when it is uncomfortable.

VIII. AI AND THE INFORMATION ASYMMETRY

From Information to Judgement

A participant with experience as CEO, chair and director offered a reframing that resonated widely. Using Ludo's four factors, boards tend to be good at the last two – strategy and leadership – and align quickly on them. Most problems arise in the first two: understanding the environment and the organisation. Seen this way, the question is perhaps less whether the roles have changed – if the governance structure

is right, they arguably should not have – than whether the information flow has changed.

In most companies it has not. Information still reaches the board as documents prepared and tabled by management, rather than through direct access to systems. This creates both an information gap and a time gap. Management controls what is provided and when; the temptation is to try to fix a problem first and only bring it to the board when it can no longer be fixed – which is usually when it is too late. AI, the participant argued, now makes it realistic to give the board the same access to company systems as management, enabling boards to understand the environment and the organisation far better.

"Regarding AI, it is less about the roles and more about the tools. The board should have the same access as management – otherwise you always get information gaps and time delays."

A counterweight: governance of AI at board level

David voiced a note of caution. Boards are now offered AI tools of every kind, and even AI agents positioned as quasi board members capable of issuing an opinion on almost anything. Beyond the legal constraints that still apply, giving every director unrestricted AI-enabled access to all information could create chaos. What happens to the process by which management develops a strategy, tests it rigorously and then proposes it to the board? Some form of governance over the use of AI at board level will be needed.

Judgement is the scarce resource

Ludo connected both views to a classroom observation: students now prepare case discussions with the same AI tools and arrive with the same answers, defeating the purpose of a discussion meant to surface different views. The key question is how to preserve judgement – and governance is judgement. In his view, the next board discussion will no longer be about capturing information, which AI can supply, but about exercising judgement on what it means. That should make board meetings more interesting: it becomes one director's judgement against another's. Which brings the argument back to diversity – and to his conviction that a plurality of views produces better answers than any enlightened specialist, because specialists are known to be biased, and that enlightened people do not remain enlightened, that the lights tend to dim with time and that one is enlightened at best on a few items, but certainly not over a wide scope of issues.

Ludo also expressed the hope that AI, by improving the quality of information available to boards, might finally allow them to become fully responsible – rather than being permanently behind and, at times, steered by executives selling their strategy.

"The next board discussion is no longer about capturing the information – AI gives you that. It is about exercising judgement. Governance is judgement."

— Ludo

IX. BUILDING THE BOARD AS A TEAM

Psychological Safety, Shared Learning and Honest Feedback

A participant joining online returned to the theme of relationships. In a crisis, people retreat to their corners and think about themselves, the chair or their constituency. The only thing that keeps the focus on the company is people's ability to speak up under pressure – which requires psychological safety. The participant had seen boards become more creative in deliberately building moments that develop relationships:

- Joint strategy breakouts. At an annual strategy retreat, board members and executives worked in mixed breakout groups on different angles of the strategy before reconvening. This did not co-opt the strategy process, but it opened up the dilemmas and produced a very different dynamic and outcome.
- Joint learning sessions. Learning together on subjects such as AI, where nobody claims to be the expert, creates both a shared understanding and a human bond that makes it easier to speak up later.
- Travelling together. Annual board trips, site visits and expert sessions change the nature of conversation – and boards that do this well tend to handle crises better.

Learning expeditions

Ludo responded with the example of a European brewer that went on to become a global industry leader. Its board would travel to a market for two days. On the first morning, directors visited bars – including those of competitors – and simply asked questions; in the afternoon they visited hypermarkets and supermarkets, collecting observations. The next morning, the CEO took the board through the business, and directors tested management against the data they had gathered themselves. Only in the final half-day did the formal board meeting take place. The board had spent a day and a half exploring, discussing and building relationships before any decision was taken.

The board found this so valuable that it added a full one-week learning expedition, designed with a leading management thinker. Later, when the company combined with another group of owners, a joint programme brought the two ownership families together to examine the key challenges of the market – and to learn from each other. Ludo noted that such settings also reveal talent: observing the younger generation, one could already see the future directors and executives.

"You have to structure the learning, and you have to manage the conversations. Be creative on governance. Avoid routine."

— Ludo

When the chair is the problem

A participant who had co-designed strategy with a board as an executive emphasised that the key to success had been the chair, who created enough safety for executives to challenge the board – not only the other way round. That is not common and needs to change. But how can a chair be coached through such a change?

Ludo's answer had three parts. First, in owner-led companies, the owners' board must keep asking whether it has the right board – the owners' key skill is not to chair, but to appoint and oversee the chair. Second, in governance one can always do something and quickly, like changing the chair, or a few directors. It is the best acknowledgement of the board of the crisis. Resigning is another option. But do not resign in silence. Drawing on personal experience, he described leaving a board over conduct he could not accept and stating the reason clearly in writing – after which the chair thanked him for putting the fish on the table. Directors are collegially responsible; sometimes the issue simply has to be named.

Anonymous feedback at the end of every meeting

Third, and most practically, Ludo recommended a short anonymous survey at the close of each board meeting, completed by both executives and non-executives, using a simple scale from 0 to 5:

1. Do the executives leave with a higher sense of mission?
2. Did participants learn something from the meeting?
3. Does the meeting make the executives better at their jobs?
4. Is the company different because of the meeting – or was the board merely a debating society?
5. Does the future look clearer – is there less fog?

The chair should review the results with the lead or senior independent director and agree what to do about them. A participant who had chaired a board of 25 members, many of them ex officio, confirmed the value of the tool: used consistently, it means that nobody can hide – directors had to lean in and show why they were there, issues raised could be fixed by the next meeting, and momentum built. And, as another participant added, the chair cannot hide either when confronted with feedback on the board as a collective.

Several participants stressed that the survey works best combined with the team-building practices described above: results are only useful if there is a safe space to discuss them. Most problems in boards still stem from a lack of courage to put the fish on the table. Culture eats strategy for breakfast – and a board that does not build its own governance culture should not be surprised by what follows.

X. THE RED LINE

What Is Good for the Company?

In closing, each co-moderator was asked for the sentence he wanted participants to take home.

"Good for the company. That is the guideline we should all have in mind – and it can be a very helpful guidepost for almost any question we face."

— David

Ludo's closing reflections drew the threads together:

- Governance is not execution. It is a team sport, and a multi-team sport: the directors together, and the three boards – owners, directors, executives – together.
- Every director can make a difference – in either direction. Governance is a people game.
- Two is structurally a bad number. With two parties, one soon dominates or the room splits into camps.
- Good governance lives in the middle, and what is good in the middle is what is good for the company, not what is good for me.
- Depersonalise. It should not matter who said what – which is why anonymous feedback helps. Try first to understand what people are saying rather than decoding who they are.
- Be more data-driven, and search for the truth – about what the company could truly be.

XI. SYNTHESIS

Council or Director? What the Session Suggests

The session did not produce a simple verdict on the title question, but it reframed it. A council can bring frontier knowledge into the room faster than any election cycle. Yet the discussion consistently located the real constraint elsewhere:

- Philosophy comes first. Without a shared view of what the board is for – and for whom – a council merely adds more information to a board that already struggles to agree on what it means.
- Expertise belongs to the right level. Owners, directors and executives each need different advice. A council attached to the wrong body – or used to avoid reforming the board itself – risks becoming a parliament.
- Seats are for judgement. As AI reduces the scarcity of information, the value of a director lies increasingly in judgement, and in the diversity of minds that sharpens it.
- Relations make structures work. Shared learning, psychological safety and honest feedback determine whether diverse expertise – inside or beside the boardroom – turns into better decisions.
- The red line is the test. Whatever the architecture, every choice should pass one question: is this good for the company?

"A council only adds wisdom to a board that knows what it is for."

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